Monday, February 5, 2024
Magh 22, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaga Dashami

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 51 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

WINTER SESSION OF HOUSE BEGINS TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The winter session of both the Houses of Federal Parliament is begining on Monday.

According to the parliament secretariat, the meetings of both the House of Representatives and National Assembly are summoned for 4:00 pm on Monday.

The government has said that it will pass several important bills from the winter session of the parliament.

Meanwhile, Speaker of the House of Representatives Devraj Ghimire said that the bills would be passed by assuring its implementation.

During the inspection of the parliament building on Sunday, Speaker Ghimire said that discussions would be carried on the bills necessary for the country and passed in the session.

He said that it was not a big deal to pass the bills instead initiatives should be taken to implement those bills.

Stating that the essence of the parliament was to pass the necessary bills, he said that the parliament should function according to the calendar.

He said that the legal arrangements for the discussion of pre-budget had come through the ordinances and the government was paying necessary attention to it.

TENURE OF BALKUMARI PROBE COMMISSION EXTENDED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The term of the Commission formed to investigate the death of two persons in Balkumari incident in Lalitpur, has been extended by 15 days.

Joint Secretary and Spokesperson for the Ministry of Home Affairs Narayan Prasad Bhattarai said that the meeting of the Council of Ministers has extended its term for another 15 days. The Commission was formed on January 1, 2024. On December 29, 2023, there was a protest in Balkumari regarding the issue of EPS language test, and in the process, two youths died when the police used force.

In the incident, a vehicle of Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala was also set on fire. Sujan Rawat, 23, and 22-year-old Birendra Shah were killed in the incident.

After the incident in which they died, the government formed a three-member probe Commission under the chairmanship of former judge of High Court Shekhar Paudel.

Former AIG Arun BC and Joint Secretary Bhattarai are members in the Commission. The government had asked the Commission to submit its report within a month.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: TRN

The federal parliament building in New Baneshwar, Kathmandu. The winter session is set to begin from today.

Six years in business
Provinces still struggle to function properly

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The provincial assemblies in the seven provinces have completed the first six years of their life. With the creation of seven provinces on September 20, 2015, and elections for the provincial assemblies held on November 26 and December 7, 2017, the PAs were created on February 4, 2018

The provincial governments were formed about two weeks after the elections, for example, the first provincial government in Karnali was formed on February 15, 2018. The PAs are celebrating February 4 as their foundation day.

The provinces have been facing criticism for being a burden to the taxpayers' money and have largely remained ineffective in terms of government and development initiatives. They have also been labeled as a 'leader management platform' for the political parties as they have the scope to offer opportunities to more of their cadres.

However, experts on federalism maintain that the cost is not a burden as the provincial structure can be managed from the resources that have been saved from scrapping the zonal and district structures that existed before the country adopted federalism.

Meanwhile, the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) which rose to the national political in a very brief period before the second federal elections in November 2022, is cashing on also the anti-province stance and opting for two-tier federalism. Even the larger political parties have expressed doubtful opinions about the future of the provinces.

Amidst such a volatile scenario, provinces have been just an extended arm of the powerful political parties at the centre. While provinces cannot act independently from the federal government and wagged their tail at the signal of their party at the centre, larger parties have also left no stone unturned to damage the reputation and operation of the provinces. As a result, in bizarre political exposition, Koshi province witnessed six chief ministers in the past six years while Bagmati had four CMs during the same period. These two provinces have continuously been the power playing field for the parties at the centre.

Similarly, the economic performance of the provinces has also been pathetic. They have been continuously relying on the centre and local level for financial resources. Even then, they never could achieve their annual revenue and expenditure target, a trend that the federal government has been struggling to come out from.

On the contrary, the federal government has made the provinces handicapped by not making umbrella laws such as acts to manage civil servants and security personnel that would govern the legal frameworks of the sub-national governments. Intergovernmental councils have turned into a sort of ritual and they only had meetings, not the progress.

Almost six years after the formation of the provincial governments, the federal government has initiated the work to unbundle/detail the list of exclusive and concurrent powers of the federation, province and local level as provisioned by the constitution of the country.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: DHERBENDRA JHA/TRN

Province Chief Hari Shankar Mishra, Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav and other leaders of Madhes Province attending 6th anniversary celebration of the province in Janakpurdham on Sunday.

Know your political guardians, PM tells indigenous people

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the indigenous communities should not forget their real political guardian.

Speaking at a programme organised on the occasion of the 3rd anniversary of the Indigenous Nationalities Commission (INC) on Sunday, the Prime Minister suggested the indigenous communities not to be confused about their leadership.

He said, "It would be difficult to protect acquired rights if political leadership that have identified and raised the issues of recognition and rights and struggled and won the legal battles are not recognised."

The Prime Minister said, "History has proved that regressive forces can raise their head if the forces which led the political movements of the past could not sustain and I urge you to pay attention to this fact."

He said that we should rise above our partisan interests and work for the well-being of more people, and the indigenous people should choose right leadership.

Stating that everyone should pay attention to the issue of how to protect the current constitution, which has resolved to build a socialist-oriented state, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "The constitution can be further strengthened, its progressive implementation can be done and initiatives should be taken from the legal front for more rights."



Prime Minister Prachanda

> History has proved that regressive forces can raise their head if the forces which led the political movements of the past could not sustain.

He said that one should abandon selfishness and work for mass benefit. Stating that the indigenous people should choose the right policies, ideas and leadership for the community, he urged people to be aware of the fact about the repeated attack by regressive forces when the transformative power becomes weak in the parliament and policy making.

Ichchha Raj Tamang slapped 3-year jail sentence, fine of Rs. 1.72 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Special Court found the owner of Civil Savings and Credit Cooperative Limited, Ichchha Raj Tamang guilty in the case of money laundering, and sentenced him to three years' imprisonment and a fine of Rs. 1.72 billion.

> Srijana Shakya Tamang, wife of Ichchha Raj, was also sentenced to one year and six months imprisonment and a fine of Rs. 1. 3 billion.

A bench of judges of the Special Court including its Chairman Tek Narayan Kunwar and members Tej Narayan Singh Rai and Murari Babu Shrestha announced the sentence and fine against Tamang.

According to Section 30 (1) (A) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2008, defendant Ichchha Raj Tamang has been fined Rs. 1.72 billion, said spokesperson and sub-registrar for the Special Court Dhana Bahadur Karki.



Similarly, Srijana Shakya Tamang, wife of Ichchha Raj, was also sentenced to one year and six months imprisonment and a fine of Rs. 1. 3 billion.

Similarly, in the case of the defendant Keshav Lal Shrestha, a fine of Rs. 256 million and imprisonment of one year and six months have been slapped.

According to spokesperson Karki, it was decided to confiscate the property registered in the names of Ichchha Raj, Srijana, Keshav Lal, Meena Shrestha, and two daughters of Ichchha Raj- Pratishka Tamang and Pratishtha Tamang.

On January 21, the Special Court found Ichchha Raj Tamang guilty and as per the order, his full fine and imprisonment were announced on Sunday, said spokesperson Karki.

DPM Khadka for speeding up expressway project

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Deputy Prime Minister and Defense Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka has observed that most of the development projects under the ministry had satisfactory progress. DPM Khadka said it during a second quarterly review meeting on Sunday.

He however directed Nepal Army to complete Kathmandu-Tarai expressway in time. The technicians involved in this project need to increase monitoring and inspection of field. Quality assurance is equally important, DPM Khadka reminded.

According to him, inter-agency coordination, adequate budget, capacity building of Nepal Army and full utilization of equipment are required to accelerate the development projects. Khadka expressed concern over limiting review meetings in formality.

On the occasion, Joint Secretary at ministry Baburam Adhikari made presentation on development projects run under ministry and Nepal Army.

> The technicians involved in this project need to increase monitoring and inspection of field.

Ministry Secretary Kiran Raj Sharma pointed out prioritizing clearing arrears. He also directed the bodies concerned to complete the projects in time to realize benefits.

Similarly, member of the National Planning Commission, Dr Ram Kumar Phunyal, viewed it was full of hassles to use riverbed materials for construction. The raw materials should be made available at local levels, he added. The NPC member also suggested ministry that it eased land acquisition and tree felling to speed up development projects.

Moreover, Chief of Army Staff, Prabhu Ram Sharma, committed to complete development projects the NA was running in the stipulated timeframe and quality.

Drone to guide elephants to safe locations in Jhapa

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Feb. 4

After the wild elephants started venturing into urban centres, posing a significant threat to the security of the locals, Damak Municipality has decided to purchase two drones to observe the animals and guide them to safe locations.

Elephants are being spotted near densely populated areas such as Birtamod, Shivasatakshi, Surunga, Damak and Kerkha within the district.

Nabin Baral, Ward Chairman of Damak Municipality-3, emphasised the necessity of drones for monitoring elephants and guiding them to safer locations.

Damak Municipality formed a committee under the coordination of Baral to propose solutions to the elephant-related damages and implement necessary measures to address the havoc caused by the elephants.

The committee put forward the suggestion of using drones to guide elephants to safer locations by emitting sirens and simulating the sound of bees.



File Photo

Damak Municipality has formally submitted a letter to the District Administration Office in Jhapa, seeking permission to use drones for controlling elephant movements. The municipality informed that obtaining approval from the district administration office is essential for drone operation. "Once the permission is granted, the procurement process for the drones will begin," Baral added.

Shankar Luitel, who is researching elephants and advocating for human-elephant coexistence, said that elephants have ventured into the city in search of salt-rich food. He highlighted the potential risks, particularly if an elephant got attracted to garbage within the urban area, which could result in significant damage.

Luitel said that the presence of picnic areas in the community forests near the city, coupled with the disposal of garbage by municipalities in the nearby forests, has attracted elephants closer to the urban areas.

"Elephants searching for food are drawn to salty sources. If they find such food readily available, they are likely to linger in the vicinity," he added.

Previously, elephants would find ample salty soil at the base of the Chure forest corridor, where they would feed on it. However, with the reduction of this food source in the forest, the challenge has escalated, leading to frequent appearances of wild elephants in human settlements.

In Jhapa, within two months, five individuals were killed in elephant attacks. The Division Forest Office in Jhapa reported that these fatalities occurred between December and January.

Additionally, two elephants were found dead during the same time. This alarming trend indicates an escalation in both human and elephant casualties, highlighting the urgent need for effective mitigation measures.

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 118900	▲
Worked Gold	: Rs. 118350	▲
Silver	: Rs. 1395	▲

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,061.70	▼
Total Amount	: 3,216,727,221.79	▼
No. of Share	: 9,272,782	▼

95% work progress in Barhabise substation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The construction of 220/132 kV substation in Barhabise Municipality of Sindhupalchowk has reached its final stage. The final phase of the construction of the substation is going on with a goal of completion within two months, according to the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA).

The power transformers to be placed in the substation have been connected. The power transformers of 220/132 kV, 160 MVA and 132/11 kV, 5 MVA are connected in the substation. The installation of substation equipment based on Gas Insulated System (GIS) technology has reached its final phase.

All the equipment to be placed in the control room have been supplied to the construction site, said the NEA. The overall progress of construction of 220/132 kV substation is about 95 per cent. Another 400 kV substation is also under construction in Barhabise.

The electricity of the 102-megawatt Madhya Bhotekoshi Hydropower Project constructed in Sindhupalchowk under the leadership of Chilime Hydropower Company, a subsidiary of Nepal Electricity Authority, will be connected to this substation.

The electricity generated from Madhya Bhotekoshi will be connected to Barhabise substation through 220 kV transmission line.

The project has already constructed towers of 220 kV single circuit transmission line of about four km long from the switchyard of its power plant to Bahrabise substation.

About two km of transmission line wire has been extended. The project is unable to expand two km of wire due to the obstruction of the local residents of Palanti located in Barhabise Municipality-3 and 4.

At present, the construction of the structures of Madhya Bhotekoshi Hydropower Project have completed and they are being tested. The NEA is under pressure to complete the Barhabise substation as soon as possible to prevent the wastage of electricity generated from the project without being connected to the national transmission line.

The NEA's high-level team including Managing Director Kul Man Ghising, and Deputy Managing Director of Transmission Directorate Dirghayu Kumar Shrestha inspected the project site Saturday and instructed to complete the remaining works swiftly.

Ghising instructed to complete the construction of the substation within two months by increasing the manpower as all the equipment have been supplied and some of the connections are in the final stage.

"The progress of the last phase of substation construction is satisfactory, the construction of new Khimti-Barhabise and Barhabise-Lapsiphedi (Kathmandu) transmission lines has also reached the final stage, if there are no other problems, the construction will be completed within next 2-3 months. Let's make the last initiative and try from our side," he said.

The construction of the substation has been delayed due to the weak performance of the joint venture of the Chinese companies Guangxi Transmission and Substation Construction and Shenzhen Claw Electronics, which received the contract for the construction of the Barhabise substation, and the COVID-19 pandemic.

The Authority has temporarily made an alternative arrangement for the electricity supply of Madhya Bhotekoshi. However, it is a compulsion for the construction of 220/132 kV Barhabise substation.



PHOTO: TRN

NEA's Managing Director Kulman Ghising inspected Barhabise substation on Sunday.

SRI LANKA SIGNS A FREE TRADE PACT WITH THAILAND

AP
Colombo, Sri Lanka, Feb.4

Debt-stricken Sri Lanka signed a trade pact with Thailand on Saturday in a bid to boost trade and investment as the Indian ocean island nation is struggling to recover from its worst economic crisis that hit two year ago.

The Sri Lanka Thailand Free Trade Agreement covering trade in goods, investment, custom procedures and intellectual property rights was signed in the capital Colombo in the presence of Sri Lanka President Ranil Wickremesinghe and Thai Prime Minister Srettha Thavisin.

Sri Lanka began talks with Thailand on a free trade agreement in 2016. The countries' two-way trade was worth about $352 million in 2022, with Thailand's exports at $292 million and Sri Lanka's exports at $58 million, according to Sri Lankan government's data.

Sri Lanka exports include mainly precious stones, apparel, tea and spices while exports from Thailand include smoked rubber sheets, natural rubber, plastic and cement. Sri Lanka's government expects the trade pact would boost two-way trade up to $1.5 billion.

Thavisin said that the countries agreed to promote investment in areas such as fisheries, food processing, tourism and green energy. Thailand has made over $92 million in direct investment in Sri Lanka from 2005 to 2022.

Giving further boost to tourism, Thavisin said that Thailand's flag carrier Thai Airways would resume daily flights from Bangkok to Sri Lanka next month. Sri Lanka has been struggling with an economic crisis since declaring bankruptcy in April 2022 with more than $83 billion in debt, more than half of it to foreign creditors. The crisis led to protests that ousted then-President Gotabaya Rajapaksa.

Severe shortages of food, fuel and medicine have largely abated over the past year under Wickremesinghe. But public dissatisfaction has grown over the government's effort to increase revenue by raising electricity bills and imposing heavy new income taxes on professionals and businesses. The International Monetary Fund approved a four-year bailout program last March to help the South Asian country.

Sri Lanka is hoping to restructure $17 billion of its outstanding debt and has already reached agreements with some of its external creditors. Calling the agreement "a milestone in the economic partnership" between the two countries, Wickremesinghe said Sri Lanka has made "significant progress in economic stabilization" since the crisis erupted.

TURKISH GOVERNOR RESIGNS ONLY MONTHS AFTER SHE SWORN

AP
Istanbul, Feb.4

The governor of Turkey's central bank has resigned only months after taking office amid allegations of improper use of power and family interference in the workings of the financial institutions.

Hafize Gaye Erkan who took over as central bank governor in June was the bank's first female chief. She announced her resignation on social media platform X, formerly Twitter, late Friday, saying she was a victim of a "character assassination campaign" and would resign to spare her family further anguish.

Last month, a leading Turkish newspaper claimed that her parents were exerting undue influence inside the financial institution and that her father had even fired a bank employee. Allegations Erkan has vehemently refuted. At the time, President Recep Tayyip Erdogan came out in support of the central bank governor, dismissing the media report as "irrational rumors designed to destroy the climate of trust and stability in the economy that we have achieved through great difficulty." The Turkish president had previous governors fired for resisting his insistence that lower interest rates would fight Turkey's staggering inflation.

Economists have blamed his unconventional economic policy that led to a major spike in the cost of living, with people struggling to afford food, housing and other necessities. However, Erdogan reversed course after winning elections in May, appointing a new economic team headed by former Merrill Lynch banker Mehmet Simsek, who returned as finance minister and who brought on Erkan as the new governor. Under Erkan's tenure, loan rates increased from 8.5% to the current 45%, the latest spike enforced last week.

Farmer's struggle in Europe effects on food supply

AP
Boussy-Saint-Antoine, France, Feb.4

Truck driver Jeremy Donf understands French farmers are struggling and he wants to support local food producers. But like many consumers, buying French produced food isn't always an option.

Farmer protests across Europe this week have highlighted how farmers and households are both hurting these days because of multiple factors, including persistent inflation, high interest rates and volatile energy prices.

"We understand their anger because we value farmers. What are we going to do if they are not here? We won't eat. Such protests are important," Donf said. But as he weighed Spanish-grown lemons in his suburban Paris supermarket, Donf noted that most of the produce around him was imported. And when French-grown food is available, not everyone can afford it. In a Paris market this week, Moroccan clementines and Polish mushrooms cost about half the price of their French counterparts. The farmer protests drew widespread public support in France, even from truckers like Donf whose livelihood was threatened by the highway blockades that were part of the protests. Donf lives in the Paris suburb of Boussy-Saint-Antoine but comes from the French Indian Ocean island of Reunion, where farming is important and many people buy directly from local farmers.

Governments including France, Spain and Greece agreed in recent days to pump hundreds of millions of euros into the farming sector to calm the protesters. The EU also granted concessions to farmers, sensitive to voter concerns ahead of European Parliament elections in June.

At a nearby farmers' market this week, several shoppers specifically chose more expensive French meat and vegetables over cheaper imports, in part spurred by the recent protests.

"I am well aware that it's not easy for some people to spend more money on food, but since my pension allows me to do it, I decided to favor high-quality (French) products," said Patrick Jobard, a retiree.

Greek farmers dump produce outside an agricultural fair

AP
Thessaloniki, Greece, Feb. 4

Greek farmers dumped chestnuts and apples on the pavement outside an agricultural fair Saturday and promised to escalate protests after a Tuesday meeting.

Those who did the dumping were from the Thessaly region, in central Greece, who came to the northern Greek city of Thessaloniki on buses to join their colleagues from the north who had come with their tractors Friday.

In recent months, similar protests have swept Europe as farmers on the continent take their grievances over inflation, foreign competition and the costs of combating climate change to the streets.

"The millions of euros that the prime minister says he is giving us to cut down on production costs are a pittance," said Kostas Tzelas, a farmers' federation leader from Thessaly, referring to promises of support by Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis.

The prime minister "said nothing about us losing income from the (European Union's) Common Agricultural Policy. If he wants us to remain in Greece and not emigrate, he must solve our problems," he added.



The farmers from Thessaly left following their protest, while those from northern Greece will remove their tractors Sunday. But they, and others from across Greece, will meet Tuesday and will likely decide to escalate their protests, including blocking highways.

Farmers have derided the government's proposal for a meeting with Mitsotakis, calling it a photo-opportunity event. "The last thing we care about is a meeting with the prime minister," Tzelas said.

Low snowfall leaves upper Manang farmers worried

BY YADU PRASAD BHATTARAI
Manang, Feb. 4

Farmers in Manang district are increasingly concerned about the absence of snowfall this year. The lack of timely snow poses several challenges, including irrigation problems, absence of grass for cattle, lack of moisture needed for apple trees, heightened risk of disease and insect infestation and reduced grain quality.

Manang has witnessed very low snowfall this year. It has snowed in the lower regions of Manang and the upper areas of Manang are yet to receive snowfall this year. Therefore, the favourable conditions for the growth of crops, fruits and grass are hindered, complained the locals.

Yangdu Gurung, 84, a yak herder, said, "I have three dozen yaks and finding enough grass for them has been a challenge due to the absence of snow in the lower range."

Likewise, Yuba Raj Gurung, the head of Agro Manang, expressed concerns about the potential difficulties in expanding apple cultivation this year due to the absence of snow.

He said, "If there was snow, the apple trees could be relocated, ensuring their survival. However, this year, the lack of snow will result in insufficient moisture for the apple trees."

Gurung said, "We typically rely on snowfall for irrigation. After snowfall its gradual melting would provide sufficient water for the apple plants, eliminating the need for additional irrigation. However, there is no snow this year, and it has posed challenges for crops and fruits."

He explained that the absence of snow would lead to reduced water availability for the apple plants. This could result in the fall of flowers, poor growth of apples and an increase in diseases and insect infestations.

Santosh Sherchan, Chief of the Manaslu Conservation Area Project, also highlighted the negative impact of the absence of snow on farming and animal husbandry in the Himalayas.

He added that this is the season for planting potatoes, apples, and walnuts, and the lack of snow directly affects both production and marketing.

Dhak Bahadur Bhujel, Chief of Annapurna Conservation Area Project (ACAP) Manang, said that the lack of snow leads to the drying up of water sources, impacting agriculture, tourism, and wildlife in Upper Manang.



PHOTO: YADU PRASAD BHATTA/TRN

Yaks grazing grasses in the ground.

Taplejung Land Revenue Office raises Rs. 10.6 million revenue

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Feb. 4

The Land Revenue Office, Taplejung has collected revenue of around of Rs. 10.6 million during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

According to Nirmal Sherpa, chief of Land Revenue Office, Taplejung, revenue of around Rs. 10.6 million has been collected by mid-January of the current fiscal year.

Out of the total amount, Rs. 6 million has been collected under the land registration fees and Rs. 4.6 million under capital gains during the review period of the current fiscal year, he said.

The number of land registrations has reached 698 during the first six months of the current fiscal year. The revenue collection of the Office has decreased during the review period as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

The Office had collected revenue of Rs. 6.5 million under the land registration fees and Rs. 7.3 million under the capital gain tax during the first six months of the last fiscal year. On the other hand, the revenue collected for land registration will be distributed to the local and provincial governments, said Sherpa.

According to him, there is an arrangement to share revenue at the rate of 60 per cent to the local level and 40 per cent to the provincial government. He informed that the revenue amount collected for capital gains tax will be deposited in the account of the federal government.

Advanced CCTV monitoring in Budhanilkantha

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The Kathmandu Valley Police Office, Ranipokhari, has started direct surveillance of the Budhanilkantha area of Kathmandu from Sunday.

With the installation of 181 CCTVs based on Artificial Intelligence (AI) in different areas of Budhanilkantha, now the daily activities of the area will be directly monitored from the control room of the Valley Police, Ranipokhari.

The CCTVs were installed through the joint effort of the Valley Police and the Budanilkantha Municipality to make the campaign Safe Kathmandu Valley: Our Commitment, a reality.

According to SSP Dinesh Raj Mainali of the Valley Police Office, an agreement to install the CC cameras was inked with the municipality on April 25, 2023 at a cost of Rs. 50 million.

The Valley Police has started surveillance of the area from Saturday after the installation of CCTVs was completed, said SSP Mainali, Spokesperson for the Kathmandu Valley Police Office.

Chief of the Kathmandu Valley Police Office, Additional Inspector General of Police Deepak Thapa and Budhanilkantha Municipality Mayor Mitha Ram Adhikari jointly inaugurated the operation of the CC camera.



PHOTO: TRN

Chief of the Kathmandu Valley Police Office, Additional Inspector General of Police Deepak Thapa and Budhanilkantha Municipality Mayor Mitha Ram Adhikari jointly inaugurating the operation of CCTVs.

Spokesperson Mainali said that under the Safe Kathmandu Plan, a total of 181 artificial intelligence (AI)-based CCTVs have been installed at 79 locations along the Budhanilkantha route, Man Bahadur Marg-Chunikhel route and Kapan route with 174 permanent CC cameras including seven PTZs (Pan-tilt-zoom) cameras and a robotic camera capable of panning horizontally, tilting vertically and zooming.

On the occasion, Mayor Adhikari, said that they will work hand in hand with the Kathmandu Valley Police Office to maintain peace, security and control crime in the Budhanilkantha area. He said that the CCTV connection has been completed in the first phase and now support would also be provided in the second phase.

During the ceremony, Head of Kathmandu Valley Police Office Ranipokhari, Additional Inspector General of Police Thapa expressed his belief that the CCTV cameras would contribute significantly to maintain peace and security in the area as well as controlling criminal activities in the Kathmandu Valley as a whole.

He said that he would continue to cooperate with the municipality in the future as well.

131 makeshift shelters handed over to local governments

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Feb. 4

One hundred and thirty one temporary houses built for the earthquake victims in Jajarkot and Rukum West have been handed over to two municipalities.

In Nalgadh Municipality of Jarjarkot and Aathbiskot Municipality of Rukum West, 131 temporary shelters constructed in the financial support of Start Fund Nepal and in collaboration with Panchtara Youth Forum and the World Vision International were handed over to the local government.

Such temporary shelters were built for those families who were very poor, single women and people who had not received any support before.

The shelters were built in Nalgadh-6 and Aathbiskot Municipality-4 taking permission from the District Disaster Management Committee and the local level government, according to Chhavi Panta, chairman of Panchtara Youth Forum.

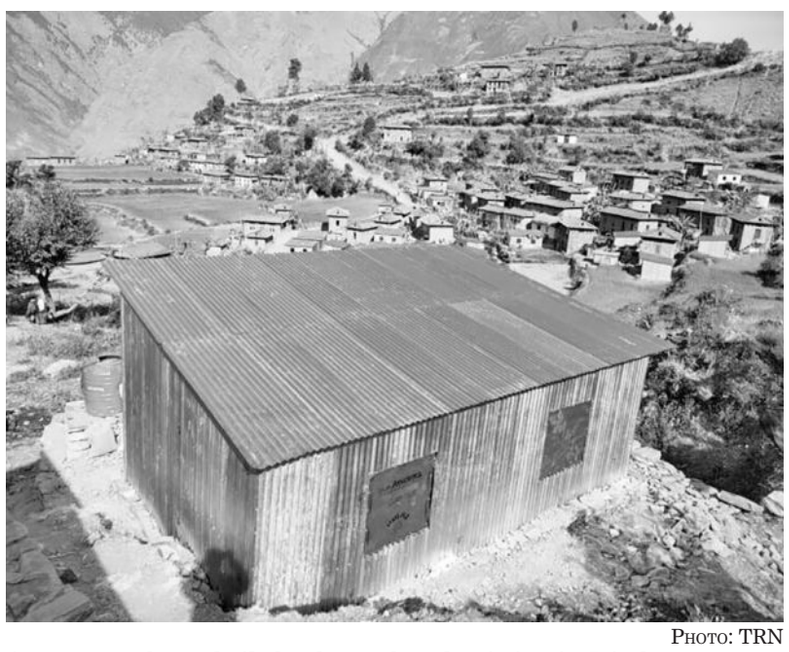


PHOTO: TRN

A temporary house built for the earthquake victims in Jajarkot.

Iron rod and coloured corrugated sheets were used to construct the shelters along with toilets and drinking water facilities. The 131 temporary shelters were prepared at a cost of Rs. 24 million.

Dharan to host Limbu students' convention

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Feb. 4

The Limbu Students' Forum Central Working Committee is going to organise its second international general convention in Dharan from March 19 to 23.

With the theme of 'Unity for Existence', the convention of the Limbu students will be held at Bijayapur of Dharan.

Dharan also hosted the first international general convention of the Limbu students from October 19 to October 21, 2016.

According to Nitesh Singak, coordinator of the convention, the second convention is going to be organised as a continuation of the first convention.

Integrating the Limbu students in the world emotionally and uniting the community by holding extensive discussions on various aspects related to Yakthung Limbu are the main objects of the second convention, said Singak.

According to him, over 1,000 students from 14 districts of Nepal and 17 countries including India, Bhutan, America, the UK, Australia, Japan, Germany and France will participate in the convention.

> Integrating the Limbu students in the world emotionally and uniting the community by holding extensive discussions on various aspects related to Yakthung Limbu are the main objects of the second convention, said Singak.

More than 22 different topics including the history and script development of the Limbu language, linguistic movement and higher education in the mother tongue, development of the Limbu language curriculum and Kirat religion and culture, the influence of Yuma religion and philosophy in the community and the kipat system of Limbuwan will be discussed in the convocation, he added.

Bird population shrinking in Narayani River bank area

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Feb. 4

The wetlands in the Nawalpur area which play a vital role in providing habitat for various species, regulating water flow, improving water quality and supporting local communities have shrunk in recent years due to anthropogenic activities. Destruction of the wetlands has endangered various bird species, including eagles, kingfishers, grey herons, coots and storks in the area.

Tikaram Giri, president of the Bird Education Society, said that a quarter of Nepal's 168 endangered bird species are now under threat. He added that alongside the destruction of wetland habitats, waterbirds face crises because of illegal bird hunting and trade, obstruction of flight paths and the effect of climate change.

He added that bird species dependent on wetland habitats, such as lakes, ponds, rivers, reservoirs, irrigated fields and marshy grasslands have significantly declined in recent years.

Sudhan Lamsal, a resident of Kawasoti, said that he observed a significant reduction in bird sightings following the destruction of wetlands in the village. He added that unplanned urbanisation, pollution, and shrinking of wetlands due to human encroachment and the recently constructed concrete pond on wetlands of Chitwan National Park has dwindled the population of waterfowls, both native and migratory.

A concrete pond has been constructed on the wetland situated in the central part of Chitwan National Park. Following the drying up of the marshland, the water birds that used to be previously observed in this area began to disappear.



PHOTO: TRN

Various species of birds are flying at wetlands in the Nawalpur area.

DB Chowdhary, waterfowl census coordinator of the West Sector of Chitwan National Park, said, "Rivers are being contaminated by sewage and garbage thrown in sources of water, leading to drying up of water bodies. So, the bird population has diminished compared to previous years, as crucial habitats of migratory birds in the vicinity of Chitwan National Park are shrinking."

According to Chaudhary, "Human activities have led to the shrinking of wetlands adversely affecting aquatic birds both native and migratory. This stark reality is well illustrated in the recent bird counts, where declining numbers directly reflect the consequences of human intervention."

Ornithologist Basu Bidari said that among the 43 globally rare bird species recorded in Nepal, 12 species are water birds. The number of migratory waterfowl is decreasing due to human activities and development works carried out around wetlands.

Currently, 551 species of birds have been listed in the Narayani River bank area.

25-YEAR-OLD PRIVATE VEHICLES TO BE SCRAPPED

RSS
Gandaki, Feb. 4

Privately-owned vehicles will have to be scrapped after running for 25 years in Gandaki Province. This is the first time that such a provision has been made for private vehicles in the country. Earlier, such provision was applied only to public transport vehicles. The federal law does not allow the ply public vehicles older than 20 years.

The new provision comes into effect in Gandaki province, after the Gandaki Province Vehicle and Transport Regulations, 2080, was published in the provincial gazette last Thursday.

Spokesperson of the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development and Transport Management, Tikaram Paudel, said that the age of private vehicles has been set at 25 years for the first time in Nepal. There is already a provision for public vehicles to be scrapped after 20 years.

For e-public vehicles, the limit is 30 years. It is mentioned in the regulations that the ministry can create and issue necessary standards to convert public and other vehicles into electric vehicles.

Spokesperson Paudel said that the regulations have also provided legal ground to regulate and legalise the transport services provided through the Ride Sharing app. Transportation service can be provided through the use of the Ride Sharing App at specified fares after completing the necessary procedures along with passenger insurance.

The regulations have also increased the fine to be paid by taxis that do not run on the meter system. From now on, the minimum rate of fine will be increased to Rs. 10,000 from existing Rs. 2,100.

Furthermore, the road permit license can be suspended for six months as the maximum penalty.

Around 3,500 taxis are operating in Gandaki province with 2,500 them in Pokhara alone.

NEWS BRIEF

Jewelry shop owner sustains bullet injury

Nawalparasi West: Gajendra Bishwakarma, a 62-year-old gold and silver businessman of Bardghat Municipality-4, was shot on Saturday night.

Deputy Superintendent of Police and Information Officer Resham Bohora of the District Police Office Nawalpur said that when he was returning home after closing his shop in Susta Rural Municipality-1 Baruv, near Kukurmara in Bardghat Municipality-16, an unidentified group fired one round of bullet at Bishwakarma at around 7 pm yesterday.

DSP Bohora said that Bishwakarma, who was injured by the bullet, is currently receiving treatment at the Universal College of Medical Sciences Teaching Hospital, Bhairahawa. He was shot in the arm.

The search for the shooter is continuing, police said. Injured Bishwakarma's scooter number with registration number LU 78 P 7435 was found in ward-14, four kilometres away from the incident site.

Constable kills wife and son in hotel

Ghorahi: A policeman has been arrested in Dang for allegedly killing his wife and son.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Janak Bahadur Malla said that 32-year-old police constable Pimlal Nepali working at the District Police Office Dang was detained for murdering his 22-year-old wife Tika B.K. and his two-and-a-half-year-old son Sushant Nepali.

Nepali, who had asked for leave from the office on Saturday night saying that his wife had come from Nepalgunj, was staying in room No. 1 of the Super Lodge Hotel at Shahid Gate in Ghorahi on Saturday.

It has been revealed from a preliminary investigation that Nepali strangled his wife and son with the shawl of his wife and killed them after a dispute at 7:00 am on Sunday.

DSP Malla, who is also the spokesperson for the District Police Office, said that after committing the crime Nepali himself attended the police office.

Nepali is a permanent resident of Runtigadhi Rural Municipality-9, Rolpa was working at the Police Training Centre in Nepalgunj for a long time. He was transferred to Dang only two months ago.

(TRN)

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The real man smiles in trouble, gathers strength from distress, and grows brave by reflection.
- Thomas Paine

EDITORIAL

Equip Healthcare Well

The groundwork for all happiness is good health, says Leigh Hunt. Yes, without good health, a person can't lead a meaningful life no matter how much material wealth one accumulates. So health comes first over any other priorities of life. But an individual alone can't be able to afford for sound physical and mental life. This demands state's greater role in ensuring quality and affordable health services to all citizens irrespective of their social and economic status. Nepal's constitution has made it mandatory for the state to provide free basic health services to every citizen. Although health is a fundamental right of the people, it has been a herculean task for the state agencies to meet this constitutional requirement owing to the insufficient budget and infrastructure, dearth of doctors and nurses and so on.

Moreover, health services have become costly. As state-run health posts and hospitals are running beyond capacity, the patients are compelled to visit the expensive private hospitals, clinics and nursing homes to get quality health services. This naturally impels the government to extend sufficient financial support to the state-run medical centres so that they are equipped with advanced technology, competent doctors and other facilities. Modern medical equipment is one important element in guaranteeing the effective and quality healthcare services. The medical professionals largely rely on the equipment to precisely diagnose and treat the patients. Therefore, the concerned agencies have to follow rigorous process to procure the health equipment. After their purchase and installation in the health centres, competent technical hands should be manned to use and maintain them properly.

A news report, carried by this daily on Sunday, sheds light on the achievements made in the procurement of medical equipment, especially after the country was restructured into federal set-up. It states that the three-tier governments have given due priority to purchasing medical equipment bearing in mind their needs and budget limitation. The concerned authorities have said that the administrative process of procurement is complex, requiring careful analysis of minimum standards and specific equipment as required by the government hospitals. There is the need for strategic planning for a collaborative approach among the three tiers of government so that they optimise resource allocation and avoid duplicity. Similarly, it is necessary to consult experts such as doctors and biomedical engineers to ensure the practical needs and the standards of equipment before purchase process is finalised. They must meet international standards and quality.

Challenges also lie in their safe delivery from the origin to destination countries. In view of rapid development of technology, the priority should be given to buying latest version equipment manufactured as per new medical research. Availability of skilled healthcare professionals is vital to handle such equipment. In order to remove complexity in procurement, the related ministry has forwarded proposals for the amendment of the Public Procurement Act. It has asked to include the provisions such as standardised criteria to acquire medical equipment, maintain consistency in quality and pricing through centralised bidding system. It has taken measures to institutionalise procurement information systems, and enhance contract management and procurement and supply management capacities. The government needs to mobilise resources to properly utilise the expensive and sophisticated equipment so that they do not lie idle and taxpayers' money is not wasted.

Mindless Wars

BISHALYA GAUTAM

Human conflict has changed over time, moving from ape-like battles for survival to contemporary violence that is often driven by territorial claims. Early conflicts were centered on resources, whereas modern conflicts mostly concern territorial expansion and geopolitical power, reflecting the intricate processes guiding civilisation's path.

People often criticise wars, yet admire ancient conquerors, revealing a conflicting view of violence. Many have questioned why wars happen, but finding a clear answer remains difficult. Certain conflicts find clear justification when undertaken to thwart tyranny or combat menacing political ideologies. The Allied invasion of German-occupied territories in Europe during World War II exemplifies a morally imperative action. Confronting the threat posed by the Axis powers, this intervention aimed at liberating oppressed nations and countering the expansion of an oppressive regime, making it an essential and ethically justifiable act for many people.

Some wars, such as the invasion of Iraq by the United States and its allies, give rise to concerns about exaggerated explanations by powerful states. The alleged necessity, which is based on the discovery of weapons of mass destruction, is not well supported. This draws attention to the potential abuse of power, raising doubts about the real motivations behind these interventions and highlighting how crucial it is to carefully consider the justifications offered for using force.

Moreover, as seen by Tsar Nicholas II's outbreak of the Russo-Japanese War, wars can be skillfully employed to resurrect popular support during periods of governance crisis. But this popularity-seeking stunt backfired, humiliating the Tsar. This emphasises the unpredictable outcomes and possible dangers that could arise when nations use conflict to gain political leverage during their vulnerabilities.

Innumerable violent acts throughout history have raised a complicated and nuanced question of who suffers the most. Throughout hostilities, citizens, soldiers, and entire towns are among the victims. Violent events have long-lasting effects that highlight their pervasiveness, such as loss, displacement, and trauma. Ultimately, the circumstances and dynamics of every historical conflict have an enormous effect on the degree and nature of suffering.

Even in the most distinct historical situations, atrocities are a common experience that unites people. Morally reprehensible acts, such as war crimes, and human rights abuses, are not limited to particular conflicts. These acts cause great suffering and leave a legacy of psychological and physical damage, whether they are directed at combatants or civilians. These parallels demonstrate the importance of addressing moral questions on the longstanding human cost of violence.

The validity of Russia's recent invasion of Ukraine, which Vladimir Putin defended as an essential step to stop oppression of ethnic Russians in Ukraine, has come under scrutiny. In a similar vein, the Israel-Hamas war is intertwined with complex theological issues and raises the possibility of ethnic cleansing, yet no one is able to look to the facts.

In summary, the quest of peace has to take precedence over the turbulent course of conflict. The blood of innumerable lives lost in countless wars serves as a constant reminder of the irrevocable cost of humankind. Generations later, the effects of war, which is frequently caused by flawed beliefs or political ambitions, linger. It becomes essential to embrace communication, understanding, and diplomacy to end vicious cycle of wars. Considering the damage done to individuals, families, and societies, we must all make a commitment to promoting a world in which disagreements are settled amicably and cooperatively rather than using the destructive machinery of war.

Ukraine's Ugly, Unequal War



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

In the two years of war so far, Ukraine remains awash in chaos and destruction since Russian troops entered Europe's second-largest country. With the $100 billion dollars in weapons, equipment and other material supplies from NATO nations, it could clearly be collapsing. Going by the prevailing situation, historians could term the war as the charade of victory that never was. Things might have been different if NATO had stepped in with troops to counter the Russians in direct confrontation.

Some political leaders and analysts assess the Ukraine war as not in Europe's interests but that of the United States. Washington's strategy of sanctions against Moscow has had sharp economic repercussions on Europe. Supply stoppage of Russian gas has soared production costs and contributed to higher inflation rates than recorded in previous decades.

Propaganda campaign through various channels, including prominent news outlets, fed their audiences throughout 2022 that Russians were fighting "World War II weapons" and were in overall short supply of men and material. This misled the general public. The pattern spilled over with relative effect for the first half of 2023, too. Since last summer, the misleading march got exposed. It has dawned on millions of people not only in Europe but billions elsewhere that Kyiv is not winning the war that is getting decisive in its destructive nature. Ukraine is seen as being the eventual loser.

Lone on ground

Notwithstanding the billions of dollars' worth of weapons and other supplies, Ukraine is visibly on the back foot. It is the lone warrior when it comes to fighting the next-door superpower that views Kyiv's cosying up with NATO membership as a grave security threat. Moscow senses alarming bells against its security interests, given that Ukraine's joining the military alliance would allow NATO troops to be deployed along its 2300 km border with Russia.

From the very beginning, it was a losing battle between a superpower neighbour and a far weaker nation cajoled by NATO leaders that dangled heavy and sophisticated weapons at Zelensky. Early efforts at peace agreements were derailed, widely believed to be at Washington's intervention. Promises more in terms of war reparations to be extracted from the invading neighbour, Zelensky had heady ideas of emerging as a hero against what he saw as Goliath in Russian President Vladimir Putin. But things did not turn out quite that way.

Ukraine's powerful supporters stand unwilling to fight alongside the troops they back with aid and assistance does not contribute to a level playing field. Blatant underreporting by the mass media in the West that give thread bare reportage on Russian weaknesses and speculations quoting dubious sources misinform the public within and outside the borders of the warring sides. To borrow a noted remark on fooling people, propagandists can make all the people believe untruths for some time; they can make some people believe in false information all the time; but they by no means succeed in making all the people fall for the false all the time.

In the closing weeks of December, Zelensky wanted fighting age youth back from countries that shelter them as refugees. Nearly two months later,

> Should the war get extended, Zelensky risks facing public wrath, especially if the war ended indecisively or with losing territories.

the response has been dismal. The army needs 500,000 more troops, even as the president's January 1 message claimed that Ukraine has become "stronger". The statement might have been easy to deliver but extremely hard to convince Ukrainian people, let alone the rest of the world.

Two years of an ugly, unequal war has divided not only Ukrainians but also their key foreign backers on either side of the Atlantic. It has divided Europe and NATO. Nation first is slowly but clearly gaining ground with renewed vigour in the West. Worried about being flooded with ethnic/religious minorities that do not "integrate" in Danish way of life and culture, Denmark expects refugees to return to their country after the war. They will not be given permanent visa, as they are "completely different from Danes".

The Danish outlook seems to be shared by many of its first cousins in Europe. It echoes in the fact that NATO member Turkey is not aboard the European Union. However, the war in Ukraine did not prevent Turkey from saving $2 billion in oil imports from Russia while Germany, NATO's economic backbone, had to pay $1 trillion more. Turkey-first policy worked better since EU mandate does not apply to Turkey.

In December, NATO Secretary-General Jens Stoltenberg alerted the Western military alliance to be prepared for bad news from the Ukrainian war front. He, however, hinted that continued support on an increasing scale would enable Kyiv to ultimately land in victory. The optimism that, if adequately equipped, Ukraine's victory is a distinct probability sounds far-fetched. On the other hand, Finland admitted that the West had overestimated its forces, and acknowledged Moscow's capability of waging a long war. Germany's naval chief resigned after declaring that Putin "deserves respect".

Probing questions

Zelensky faces probing questions from many sections in his country. They could have been at least spared the prolonged personal and collective pains they suffer in a highly unequal war. Power equations have distinctly changed in the new millennium. New alliances are emerging for real. Although they could have been coming slowly, the Ukraine war cautioned many governments against the traditional world order that gave a disproportionate edge to US-EU combine. They realise the need for asserting themselves by seeking options and being able to have their say in greater measure than they had been able to do in the post-World War II decades.

How long will the agonising armed conflict last? Some powers might not want the immediate stakeholders in a conflict to smoke any peace pipe. Putin claims that 125,000 Ukrainian troops had been killed in the first 22 months of the war. Should the war get extended, Zelensky risks facing public wrath, especially if the war ended indecisively or with losing territories. One of Europe's poorest and among the most corrupt nations listed as 116th out of 180 countries, Ukraine will take years to rebuild what it has already lost. Honest efforts at bringing peace are called for. The ball could be in Washington's court.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Political Will Must To Curb Corruption



Ballav Dahal

Corruption is one of the major obstacles to socio-economic development of any nation or society. This type of irregularity happens when entrusted individuals or entities abuse power and authority for their personal gain. Bribery, double-dealing, embezzlement, extortion, networking, manipulation of poll outcomes, money laundering, and fraud by individuals, businesses and governments are some of the main forms of corruption. Considered a chronic disease, corruption has negative effects on everyone. This social anomaly hits the poor hard as it exacerbates poverty and inequalities. Besides, it weakens the bases of democracy and undermines the rule of law, creating a sense of hopelessness among citizens. In a society where corruption prevails, decisions made by public offices are not transparent and people hardly have trust in their political leaders and bureaucrats. Ultimately, this may lead to political and social instability.

Corruption is widespread in Nepal. Public officials appear to be misusing their power even amidst interventions by the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA), the Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of the Nepal Police and the Department of Money Laundering Investigation. That a racket was successful in sending many youths abroad illegally on a travel visa through the Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA) can be taken as a case in point. Recently, the District Police Range in Kathmandu has registered a case with the Kathmandu District Court against as many as 22 individuals on charge of human trafficking. Nine among them are immigration officers. Twelve individuals, including eight civil servants, have been at large. Since investigations have shown that they have sent people to foreign nations illegally on a tourist visa, the case has been filed for the offences of forgery of government documents and organised crime.

Abuse of authority

The police have come to know about this crime from some youths who had been unable to get through the TIA security. Investigations have revealed that immigration officers were working in collusion with middlemen and other swindlers, including travel agents. Such officers were found to have facilitated the movement of youths on a travel visa through the airport. For that, the immigration employees used to get a hefty amount of money from a travel agency arranging overseas tours. Hundreds of youths are suspected to have already left the country on travel visas. This is a fresh incident of abuse of authority. There is no doubt that the TIA has been a hub of irregularities, including gold smuggling despite efforts being made to prevent such activities.

Meanwhile, Nepal has continued to remain among the nations with rampant corruption worldwide. Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) 2023 shows that the country has been ranked in 108th position out of 180 countries and territories. In 2022, the country was ranked 110th position while its ranking was 117th in 2021. The publication has indicated that Nepal has failed to make any remarkable progress in controlling

> As a party even to the United Nations Convention against Corruption, Nepal needs to strengthen its anti-corruption institutions in order to eliminate this scourge.

corruption in 2023 as compared to 2022. Transparency International (TI), a global anti-corruption watchdog based in Berlin, releases CPI as its annual flagship publication. To measure corruption, TI applies a scale of zero to 100. Any country having zero point is considered as the most corrupt while the nation that secures 100 points is the least corrupt. Any nation with a score below 50 is regarded to have a comparatively higher rate of corruption. In 2023, Nepal got 35 points while it obtained 34 points in 2022.

According to the CPI 2023, in South Asia, Nepal has been ranked below Bhutan (26th), the Maldives (93rd) and India (93rd). However, Nepal is ahead of Sri Lanka (115th), Pakistan (133rd), Bangladesh (149th) and Afghanistan (162nd). This does not mean that Nepal has come a long way when it comes to maintaining good governance. With 90 points in CPI 2023, Denmark has topped the index for the sixth consecutive year while Finland and New Zealand secured scores of 87 and 85, respectively. With their good justice systems in operation, these developed nations are among the top scorers in the Rule of Law Index.

Successive governments in Nepal have claimed to have embraced a zero tolerance for corruption. The federal government has initiated a campaign against corruption. This move has generated much enthusiasm among the general public that the existing trend of misusing authority and resources will be checked sooner or later. Anti-corruption bodies have already cracked down on numerous notorious scams ranging from the fake Bhutanese refugees to the Lalita Niwas Land. But many other scams still remain to be investigated thoroughly. Despite some anti-corruption initiatives, the country records a series of corruption scams. Newer and bigger scams seem to be overshadowing others.

Punitive measures

The government's ongoing efforts are inadequate to contain corruption in the country. As a party even to the United Nations Convention against Corruption, Nepal needs to strengthen its anti-corruption institutions in order to eliminate this scourge. It needs no mention that the state of impunity is responsible for an increase in corruption and other irregularities. Harsh punitive measures must be taken against the guilty. It is also necessary to boycott the corrupt people socially. When this practice gains ground, the tendency among those in power to misuse their authority will stop, to a great extent.

As most corruption cases in Nepal are found linked to politicians, the political parties have a vital role to play in controlling this anomaly. They are also often blamed for giving protection to the corrupt. So, it is not easy for the nation to get rid of corruption without having a strong political commitment and will. In addition, the government needs to develop a transparent system where no one can abuse his/her power and authority.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 5, 1974

Handicraft Centre In Palpa

Tansen, Feb. 4: Palpa district Women's Organisation has established a handicraft centre at the cost of 25 thousand rupees, reports RSS

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Exploit Cement Export Potential

The news report *"Nepal to export cement worth Rs. 150 billion annually"* published in this daily on Feb. 4 brought cheers to my psyche. Our countless mountains are the infinite source of raw materials needed to produce cements, and the good news in that we are increasingly tapping into this potential.

That our cement and clinker export to India saw a dramatic rise to Rs. 1.8 billion in the first six months of the current fiscal year from Rs. 87 million in the same period last year corroborates this fact.

But it's also a reality that that export is only a drop in the ocean of our potential, which is Rs. 150 billion as mentioned by the story.

Harnessing this capacity can well be a game changer in our economy, creating abundant jobs and lifting millions out of poverty.



Doing this is also crucial to plug the huge trade deficit we run with the southern neighbour.

The government must incentivise the cement manufactures to bring this goal within reach.

Prakash Gautam
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A blonde walks into the police department looking for a job. The officer asks her some questions:

Officer: What's 2 + 2?

Blonde: Ummm... 4!

Officer: What's the square root of 100?

Blonde: Ummm... 10!

Officer: Good! Now, who killed Abraham Lincoln?

Blonde: Ummm... I dunno.

Officer: Well, you can go home and think about it. Come back tomorrow.

The blonde goes home and calls up one of her friends, who asks her if she got the job.

The blonde replies excitedly, "Not only did I get the job, I'm already working on a murder case!

46 reported dead in Chile forest fires

AP
Chile, Feb. 4



Photo: AP

Firefighters runs through a front yard as a building goes up in flames, in Vina del Mar, Chile, Saturday, Feb. 3, 2024.

Intense forest fires burning around a densely populated area of central Chile have caused at least 46 deaths, Chile's president said Saturday evening, and officials said at least 1,100 homes had been destroyed.

In a nationally televised address, President Gabriel Boric warned that the death toll could worsen as four large fires burn in the region of Valparaiso, where firefighters have struggled to reach the most threatened neighborhoods.

Boric urged Chileans to cooperate with rescue workers.

"If you are told to evacuate don't hesitate to do it," he said. "The fires are advancing fast and climatic conditions have made them difficult to control. There are high temperatures, strong winds and low humidity."

Interior Minister Carolina Tohá said earlier Saturday that 92 forest fires were burning in the center and south of the country, where temperatures have been unusually high this week.

The deadliest of the fires were in the Valparaíso region, where authorities urged thousands of people to evacuate their homes.

Meanwhile, residents in areas farther away from the fires were told to stay at home so that fire engines, ambulances and other emergency vehicles can get about on the roads with greater ease.

Tohá said two fires near the towns of Quilpué and Villa Alemana had burned through at least 8,000 hectares (19,770 acres) since Friday. One of the fires was threatening the coastal resort town of Viña del Mar, where some neighborhoods had already been hit hard.

In Villa Independencia, a hillside neighborhood on the eastern edge of the town, several blocks of homes and businesses were destroyed. Burned cars with broken windows lined the streets, which were covered in ash.

"I've been here 32 years, and never imagined this would happen," said Rolando Fernández, one of the residents who lost his home.

He said he first saw the fire burning on a nearby hill Friday afternoon and within 15 minutes the area was engulfed in flames and smoke, forcing everyone to run for their lives.

"I've worked my whole life, and now I'm left with nothing," Fernández said.

Three shelters were set up in the Valparaíso region, and 19 helicopters and more than 450 firefighters were brought into the area to help battle the blazes, Tohá said.

The fires were burning on mountains that are hard to reach, such as neighborhoods built precariously on the edge of Viña del Mar.

Officials reported power blackouts as a result of the fire, and Tohá said that in the Valparaíso region, four hospitals and three nursing homes for the elderly had to be evacuated. The fire also destroyed two bus terminals, the interior minister said.

The El Niño weather pattern has caused droughts and hotter-than-usual temperatures along the west of South America this year, increasing the risk of forest fires. In January, more than 17,000 hectares (42,000 acres) of forests were destroyed in Colombia by fires that followed several weeks of dry weather.

Namibian President dies of cancer

AP
Harare, Zimbabwe, Feb. 4

Hage Geingob, President of Namibia, one of Africa's most stable democracies, died Sunday while receiving medical treatment at a local hospital, his office announced.

The Namibian presidency said Geingob's medical team at Lady Pohamba Hospital did its best to help him, but he died with his wife, Monica Geingos, and children by his side, in a post on X, formerly Twitter.

Angolo Mbumba, Namibia's acting president, called for calm, saying in the same post that the "Cabinet will convene with immediate effect in order to make the necessary state arrangements in this regard."

Local media reported Mbumba has called for an urgent cabinet meeting.

According to Namibia's constitution, there should be an election to choose a new president within 90 days of Geingob's death.

Geingob was undergoing treatment for cancer. The 82-year-old had a colonoscopy and a gastroscopy on Jan. 8, followed by a biopsy, his office said last month.

He returned home on Jan. 31 from the United States where he had undergone a trial two-day "novel treatment for cancerous cells," according to his office. In 2014, he said he had survived prostate cancer.

Geingob, president of the southern African nation since 2015, was set to finish his second and final term in office this year. He was the country's third president since it gained independence in 1990, following more than a century of German and then apartheid South African rule.

After spending nearly three decades in exile in neighboring Botswana and the U.S. as an anti-apartheid activist, Geingob returned to Namibia as its first prime minister from 1990 to 2002. He also served in the same capacity from 2008 to 2012.

> The Namibian presidency said Geingob's medical team at Lady Pohamba Hospital did its best to help him, but he died with his wife, Monica Geingos, and children by his side, in a post on X, formerly Twitter,

Soft-spoken but firm on advancing Africa's agenda as an important stakeholder in world affairs, Geingob maintained close relations with the U.S. and other Western countries.

But, like many African leaders, he also forged a warm relationship with China, refuting claims that Beijing is aggressively asserting economic influence over countries in Africa as a form of colonialism.

Namibia, which is on the southwestern coast of Africa, enjoys political and economic stability in a region ravaged by disputes, violent elections and coups. However, the country's opposition slammed Geingob last year for endorsing disputed elections in Zimbabwe.

Condolences from various African leaders poured in on Sunday.

Parisians vote in referendum on raising parking fees

AFP
Paris, Feb. 4



Photo: AFP

Parisians will be asked to vote Sunday on whether to triple the cost of parking so-called SUVs in the French capital.

Polling stations opened in Paris on Sunday for a referendum on tripling parking costs for hefty SUV-style cars, a campaign that has drivers' groups up in arms against city hall.

Some 1.3 million Parisians are eligible to cast their ballot on the change, which would see cars weighing 1.6 tonnes or more charged 18 euros ($19.50) per hour for parking in central areas, or 12 euros further out.

Fully electric cars would have to top two tonnes to be affected, while people living or working in Paris, taxi drivers, tradespeople, health workers and people with disabilities would all be exempt. "The bigger they are, the more they pollute," Paris' Socialist mayor Anne Hidalgo said in December to justify the step.

On her watch, the city has pedestrianised many streets, including the banks of the river Seine, and built a network of cycle lanes in an effort to discourage driving and reduce harmful transport emissions.

Environmental group WWF has dubbed SUVs an "aberration", saying they burn 15 percent more fuel than a classic coupe and cost more to build and purchase.

City hall has further pointed to safety concerns about taller, heavier SUVs, which it says are "twice as deadly for pedestrians as a standard car" in an accident. The vehicles are also singled out for taking up more public space -- whether on the road or while parked -- than others.

Paris authorities say the average car has put on 250 kilograms (550 pounds) since 1990. Hidalgo, whose city will this summer host the 2024 Olympics, rarely misses a chance to boast of the environmental credentials of the town hall and its drive to drastically reduce car use in the centre.

Hashed chief demands withdrawal of US-led coalition from Iraq

AFP
Baghdad, Feb. 4



Photo: AFP

The pro-Iran Hashed al-Shaabi held a funeral in Baghdad for fighters killed in US strikes and its leader demanded the withdrawal from Iraq of US-led coalition forces.

The head of Iraq's pro-Iran Hashed al-Shaabi alliance on Sunday demanded the withdrawal of US-led coalition forces from the country following deadly strikes.

"They targeted administration offices, a (Hashed) hospital, they struck forces tasked with protecting the borders," Faleh al-Fayyad said at a funeral ceremony for members of the group killed in the US strikes.

"Targeting the Hashed al-Shaabi is playing with fire," he warned.

On Friday US strikes in the west of Iraq struck positions manned by pro-Iran groups, in response to an attack in January on a base in Jordan that killed three US soldiers.

The Hashed al-Shaabi, mainly pro-Iran paramilitaries now integrated into Iraq's regular security forces, said 16 of its fighters were killed in Friday's strikes and 36 people wounded.

"We urge the prime minister to do everything in his power to defend the sovereignty and dignity of Iraq. And this can only be done with the departure of all coalition forces from Iraq," Fayyad said.

The US-led coalition was set up in 2014 to fight the Islamic State group that had seized swathes of Iraq and neighbouring Syria, and Hashed had contributed to the defeat of the jihadists in Iraq.

There are roughly 2,500 US troops deployed in Iraq and about 900 in Syria as part of the coalition.

Tensions between the US and Iraqi governments have deepened in recent months after Washington carried out previous strikes in response to a flurry of attacks on US-led troops since the Israel-Hamas war in Gaza began in October.

Washington and Baghdad opened talks on the future of the US-led troop presence late last month after repeated demands from Iraqi Prime Minister Mohamed Shia al-Sudani for a timetable for their withdrawal.

What parents should know to protect their kids on social media

AP
New York, Feb. 4



Photo: AP

People show photos of their loved ones before the start of a Senate Judiciary Committee hearing with the heads of social media platforms on Capitol Hill in Wednesday, Jan. 31, 2024, to discuss child safety.

Social media CEOs got grilled by Senate lawmakers this week in an emotional and often heated hearing about the dangers their platforms pose to children — sexual predators, videos encouraging suicide and glorifying eating disorders, bullying and addictive features, just to name a few.

Republican and Democratic senators came together in a rare show of agreement throughout the hearing, though it's not yet clear if this will be enough to pass legislation such as the Kids Online Safety Act or other proposed measures intended to protect kids from online harms.

Even with apparent bipartisan unity, making laws and regulating companies takes time. What are parents — and teens — supposed to do in the meantime? Here are some tips on staying safe, communicating and setting limits on social media — for kids as well as their parents.

There's already, technically, a rule that prohibits kids under 13 from using platforms that advertise to them without parental consent: The Children's Online Privacy Protection Act that went into effect in 2000 — before today's teenagers were even born.

The goal was to protect kids' online privacy by requiring websites and online services to disclose clear privacy policies and get parents' consent before gathering personal information on their kids, among other things. To comply, social media companies have generally banned kids under 13 from signing up for their services, although it's been widely documented that kids sign up anyway, either with or without their parents' permission.

But times have changed, and online privacy is no longer the only concern when it comes to kids being online. There's bullying, harassment, the risk of developing eating disorders, suicidal thoughts or worse.

For years, there has been a push among parents, educators and tech experts to wait to give children phones — and access to social media — until they are older, such as the "Wait Until 8th" pledge that has parents sign a pledge not to give their kids a smartphone until the 8th grade, or about age 13 or 14. Some wait even later, like 16 or 17.

But neither social media companies nor the government have done anything concrete to increase the age limit.

"There is not necessarily a magical age," said Christine Elgersma, a social media expert at the nonprofit Common Sense Media. But, she added, "13 is probably not the best age for kids to get on social media."

The laws currently being proposed include blanket bans on the under-13 set when it comes to social media. The problem? There's no easy way to verify a person's age when they sign up for apps and online services. And the apps popular with teens today were created for adults first. Companies have added some safeguards over the years, Elgersma noted, but these are piecemeal changes, not fundamental rethinks of the services.

"Developers need to start building apps with kids in mind," she said.

Some tech executives, celebrities such as Jennifer Garner and parents from all walks of life have resorted to banning their kids from social media altogether. While the decision is a personal one that depends on each child and parent, some experts say this could lead to isolating kids, who could be left out of activities and discussions with friends that take place on social media or chat services.

Another hurdle — kids who have never been on social media may find themselves ill-equipped to navigate the platforms when they are suddenly allowed free rein the day they turn 18.

PRISM

Raccoon knocks out power for thousands

A power outage affecting thousands of customers in downtown Toronto was caused by an unlucky raccoon that wandered into the wrong place, utility officials said.

Hydro One said on social media that about 7,000 downtown customers lost power for more than two hours Thursday night and crews "determined that a raccoon made contact with our equipment at a downtown Toronto station."

Tiziana Baccega Rosa, a spokeswoman for Hydro One, told Global News that crews were able to confirm that a raccoon was behind the issue at the Church-Wellesley area transmission station "because the animal was unfortunately there on site and had perished when they arrived."

School employees hide $1 million Powerball ticket

Kentucky: A group of 30 current and former workers at a Kentucky middle school scored a $1 million Powerball prize with numbers they have been playing for years -- and hid the winning ticket in a math textbook.

The group of current and former employees from Rector A. Jones Middle School in Florence have been playing the lottery together for years, and they have been using the same set of numbers since 2019.

"We all taught at the same school at one point or another," a member of the group told Kentucky Lottery officials. "We've got counselors, admins, special-ed teachers, the school nurse ... Some have moved on or retired but we still continue to do it. We've remained buddies for all of these years."

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1783 – In Calabria, a sequence of strong earthquakes begins.
1885 – King Leopold II of Belgium establishes the Congo as a personal possession.
1905 – In Mexico, the General Hospital of Mexico is inaugurated, started with four basic specialties.
1907 – Belgian chemist Leo Baekeland announces the creation of Bakelite, the world's first synthetic plastic.
1958 – A hydrogen bomb known as the Tybee Bomb is lost by the US Air Force off the coast of Savannah, Georgia, never to be recovered.
1971 – Astronauts land on the Moon in the Apollo 14 mission.
2008 – A major tornado outbreak across the Southern United States kills 57.
2019 – Pope Francis becomes the first Pope in history to visit and perform papal mass in the Arabian Peninsula during his visit to Abu Dhabi.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

A view of Kapan monastery as seen from Jagdol in Kathmandu.

CEC Thapaliya talks by-election with DPM Khadka

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Chief Election Commissioner Dinesh Kumar Thapaliya held discussions with Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka today on the by-election to be held for 25 various posts that have fallen vacant.

In the meeting took place at the Ministry of Defence in Singha Durbar, CEC Thapaliya and DPM Khadka discussed the recently conducted National Assembly member election and the upcoming by-election, according to the DPM's Secretariat.

There is a constitutional provision by which the Election Commission can consult with the government regarding the election to the Member of the House of Representatives and the Province Assembly as well as the by-election to the vacant posts in the local levels.

The Commission has already suggested to the government to hold the by-election within mid-May this year. It is conducting the election to fill up these posts that have fallen vacant due to various reasons.

According to the Election Commission, the post of a Member each is vacant in the House of Representatives and the Province Assembly.

By-election is being held in Ilam constituency-2 for one member of the House of Representatives and in Province Assembly constituency-1, Bajhang election constituency-1, Sudur Paschim Province.

The Ilam constituency-2 seat had fallen vacant following the death on September 12, 2023 of Subas Chandra Nembang who was elected to the House of Representatives on CPN (UML) ticket from that constituency while the Bajhang provincial assembly constituency-1 had fallen vacant after the death in a road accident of Nepali Congress Province Assembly member Prithvi Bahadur Singh.

The Commission stated that currently 25 posts have fallen vacant, including one in the House of Representatives, one in the Sudur Paschim Province Assembly, two chiefs of the District Coordination Committee, one deputy-mayor of a municipality, one Chair of a rural municipality, two vice-chairs of rural municipalities and 17 ward chairs of various local levels.

41 ROHINGYA REFUGEES ARRESTED AFTER FLEEING DETENTION CENTRE

AFP
Kuala Lumpur, Feb. 4

More than 40 exhausted and hungry Rohingya refugees have been recaptured by Malaysian police following a detention centre breakout by 131 migrants from Myanmar, a senior police official said Sunday.

On Thursday, a total of 115 Rohingya migrants and 16 others -- all of them men -- rioted in their detention building before escaping the Bidor temporary immigration centre in northern Perak state.

The Rohingya experience persecution in their predominantly Buddhist homeland of Myanmar, with many fleeing to affluent, Muslim-majority Malaysia or to refugee camps in Bangladesh.

They often endure harrowing, months-long sea journeys to arrive in Malaysia by boat or sneak into the country via its porous border with Thailand.

If caught, they are usually sent to detention centres that rights groups say are typically overcrowded and filthy. One Rohingya man was confirmed killed on Thursday in a road accident as he tried crossing a highway in darkness.

The 41 Rohingya men were rearrested at a palm oil estate and in the forest surrounding the nearby towns of Tapah and Bidor after a public tip-off, Perak police chief Mohamad Yusri Hassan Basri told AFP.

"We believe many more are hiding in the forest," he said, adding that all those arrested were "hungry and exhausted". Yusri said 136 police and immigration officers are combing the forest, rivers and villages for the escapees from the latest breakout.

This is the second time in two years that such a breakout has occurred. In 2022, 528 Rohingya refugees escaped from detention in northern Penang state. Six were killed while trying to cross a highway, and hundreds of others were rearrested.

Village deserted as men leave to work in India

BY SAILENDRA ROKAYA
Bajhang, Feb. 4

Dhada village in Khaptadchhanna Rural Municpalily-3 remains deserted after the majority of the locals started migrating to India for income generation. At least one member of each household in the village is working in India.

Ram Bahadur Sarki's house has been locked for the past six years as all seven members of his family migrated to India.

Locals are struggling for subsistence due to the lack of job opportunities, so they tend to migrate to India with their whole family to make ends meet.

Raje Sarki from the same village has also moved to India along with his whole family. Similarly, Hiru Sarki, Bane Sarki, Sibu Sarki, Kantare Sarki, Harka Sarki and other 15 families have moved to India abandoning their homes.

Siddha Raj Sarki, a local, said, "I have a family of 19, only four members are left in the village. Others have gone to various cities in India in search of employment. It's been years since they left for India and they visit their villages while performing deity puja. They only stay for a day or two and then return to India."

People who migrated to India were mostly engaged in labour-intensive work, which compelled them to either keep their children at home or take them to work, as they could not afford to educate their children due to poor economic conditions.

Gauri Adhikari, chair of Ward No. 3, said that the number of people going to India has increased significantly. She said, "This problem exists nationwide. From each household, at least one member has gone to India. Instead of ward and municipal levels, provincial and federal governments should bring policies to address this burning issue."

Meanwhile, Khaptadchhanna Rural Municipality Chairperson Uttam Rokaya said that the municipality had been creating opportunities for those who returned from abroad by providing them with various skill-based training.

He said that the local level government could not stop foreign migration on its own, provincial and federal governments must address the issue.

He said, "Most of my family members are also working in India. The local government is taking initiatives to create an environment to retain people in the village."

It is a problem not just of Khaptadchhanna Rural Municipality. People from Saipal, Talkot, Masta, Thalara, Chhabis Pathivera, Durgathali, Surma, Kedarasyu and other rural municipalities have also migrated to India deserting their native villages.

Criticism of Biden sparks anger in Israel

AP
Jerusalem, Feb. 4

Criticism of President Joe Biden by a far-right minister in Israel's government sparked outrage on Sunday, underscoring the sensitivity of U.S. relations as Washington provides key support for the offensive against Hamas in Gaza. The Biden administration has expressed unwavering support for Israel since Hamas' Oct. 7 attack that triggered the war, skirting Congress to rush weapons to Israel and shielding its ally from international calls for a cease-fire.

But the White House has also urged Israel to take greater measures to avoid harming civilians and to facilitate the delivery of more humanitarian aid to Gaza. Itamar Ben-Gvir, Israel's national security minister, criticized that approach in an interview with The Wall Street Journal, saying Biden was hindering Israel's war effort and that Republican presidential candidate Donald Trump would give Israel greater latitude in fighting Hamas.

"Instead of giving us his full backing, Biden is busy with giving humanitarian aid and fuel (to Gaza), which goes to Hamas," Ben-Gvir said. "If Trump was in power, the U.S. conduct would be completely different."

His remarks drew fire from Benny Gantz, a retired general and member of Netanyahu's three-man War Cabinet, who said Ben-Gvir was "causing tremendous damage" to American-Israeli relations. In a post on X, formerly Twitter, Gantz said any disputes must be "conducted in relevant forums and not in irresponsible statements in the media."

Opposition leader Yair Lapid, also posting on X, said Ben-Gvir's remarks prove that he "does not understand foreign relations" and that Netanyahu had lost control over extremists in his governing coalition.

Netanyahu, without mentioning Ben-Gvir by name, appeared to refer to his remarks when addressing a weekly Cabinet meeting on Sunday. The prime minister thanked Biden for his support while highlighting his own experience of dealing with multiple U.S. administrations, describing a give-and-take approach to Israel's most important alliance. "There are those who say 'no' to everything, receiving applause at home, but they're also endangering vital interests," he said.

Ben-Gvir, along with other far-right figures, has called for "voluntary" mass emigration of Palestinians from Gaza and for the return of Jewish settlements, which Israel dismantled when it withdrew troops from the territory in 2005.

NC preparing for Feb 19 Mahasamiti meeting

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Nepali Congress has been making preparations to hold its Mahasamiti meeting slated for February 19 in Lalitpur.

On Sunday, party president Sher Bahadur Deuba and coordinator of main committee formed to make preparations for the meeting named coordinators of eight sub-committees to remain under the main committee.

According to a statement issued by Krishna Prasad Paudel, chief secretary of the party's Central Office, Sanepa, on Sunday, Deuba gave the responsibility of coordinator of the Publicity Sub-Committee to Meen Bahadur Bishwokarma.

Likewise, Madan Bahadur Amatya has been named coordinator of Accommodation Coordination Sub-Committee, Uday Shumsher of Food Management Sub-Committee, Dhana Khatiwada of Transportation Management Sub-Committee, Jitjung Basnet of Volunteer Mobilistaion Sub-Committee, Urmaila Nepal KC of Health Coordination Sub-Committee, Indra Bahadur Baniya Province Coordination Sub-Committee, and Jitendra Shrestha of Local Management Sub-Committee.

Weather to clear from Tuesday

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4



The Meteorological Forecasting Division has indicated that the current weather condition is expected to improve starting from Tuesday.

According to Sanjeev Adhikari, a senior meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division under the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM), the second rainfall of the season, brought about by a western disturbance, started on Saturday evening. However, this disturbance is expected to dissipate from the western part of the country by Monday evening.

The nation is witnessing a shift in precipitation patterns, ranging from occasional to light rainfall, particularly in certain areas of Gandaki, Lumbini, Bagmati, and Madhes provinces, Adhikari informed.

Cloudy conditions are forecast to persist throughout the country on Monday. Some high-altitude regions can expect snowfall, while lower areas may experience light to moderate rainfall, he informed.

Adhikari said, "Typically, temperatures would have been slightly on the rise by now, but the recent arrival of a western disturbance has led to a drop in temperatures nationwide. However, as this weather system settles, temperatures are expected to rebound once again."

Also, some places in Sudurpashchim and Karnali provinces, a few areas in Lumbini and Gandaki provinces, and some mountainous regions of Bagmati and Koshi provinces have a possibility of occasional to light rainfall, DHM said.

Since there is a possibility of light snowfall in some high-altitude and Himalayan regions of the country, DHM is requested to adopt necessary precautions and vigilance to minimise potential impacts on daily life, health, transportation, and air travel.

Additionally, it is advised to take necessary measures to stay warm and cautious.

Tenure of...

But the term of the Commission was extended after the investigation process could not be completed, said Joint Secretary Bhattarai.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Umesh Lamsal, Minister Jwala's PSO Bodhraj Danuwar and Director of EPS Branch Guru Dutta Subedi were suspended by the Ministry of Home Affairs in the wake of the incident.

Lalitpur Police Office Chief and SSP Siddi Bikram Shah and Chief District Officer Rudra Prasad Pandit were transferred following the incident.

The Cabinet meeting held on December 31 had also mandated the Commission to evaluate the role of the individuals, officials, and institutions related to the incident and recommend for actions against anyone deemed guilty.

Provinces still struggle...

Speaking at a programme organised on the occasion of the PA's establishment day in Karnali Province, its Chief Minister, Raj Kumar Sharma, expressed ire at not getting full freedom to exercise the unitary rights of the subnational government.

Stating that there was propaganda against the provinces by some regressive forces, CM Sharma said, "How can you swim in deep water when you are thrown into it with your hands and legs tied. I don't if saying this is appropriate, but the situation has been the same for us," our Surkhet Correspondent quoted the CM.

But speaking at the same programme, the Leader of the opposition party in the province, CPN-UML, Yam Lal Kandel, said that the performance of the development budget and works in the province has been terrifying.

Similarly, CM of Madhes Province Saroj Kumar Yadav said that the provinces are lagging in their performance due to the failure of the federal government to build the required legal and policy framework in time.

"Until and unless the provinces get a chance to fully exercise their rights, the federalism will have no meaning," our Dhanusha correspondent reported CM Yadav saying at the similar programme in Janakpurdham, "Although we have not run publicity campaigns to inform our good works, there have been many good works in the interest of people."

Speaking at the programme, the Parliamentary Party Leader of Nepali Congress in Madhes, Krishna Yadav, said that there have been various conspiracies to defame federalism, especially the provinces.

Likewise, the CM of Lumbini, Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary, also stressed on providing more powers to the provinces.

According to our Deukhuri Correspondent, addressing a programme in Deukhuri to mark the PA day, CM Chaudhary urged all not to doubt on the effective implementation of federalism and sought the support of all stakeholders in this drive. Lumbini announced a public holiday in the province which only drew further criticism from the business community and general people.

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Human Resources Department

Request for Application from Eligible candidates for Security Officer on contract basis

(1st date of publication : 2080/10/22 (05 February, 2024)

Nepal Airlines Corporation is seeking applications from qualified and eligible Nepali Citizens **for Security Officer** on a contractual basis. Interested individuals are invited to submit their applications along with a comprehensive CV and relevant eligibility documents, within 15 days from the initial publication date of this notice. Please address your submissions to the following :

Human Resources Department
Nepal Airlines Corporation
New Road Kathmandu Nepal
Email: vacancy2019.nac@gmail.com / hrplanning@nac.com.np
Phone: 977-01-5718557 (Ext. 2168, 2319)
For details of qualification and job specific requirements, please visit official website (www.nepalairlines.com.np) of Nepal Airlines Corporation.

Human Resources Department

'A sweeper searching country in dust'

BY AVAYA SHRESTHA
Madhyapur Thimi, Feb. 4



Former minister Keshav Man Shakya is a popular poet of Nepal Bhasa. But it has been 32 years since he stopped writing poetry.

However on Saturday, Sanjhya Sahitya presented him as one of the three guest poets at its monthly serial in Madhyapur.

"It has been 32 years since I quitted writing poetry," the ex-minister for Science and Technology said. "I thought the readers have also forgotten me, but Sanjhya remembered me and revived my passion for poetry."

The audience loved all five poems he recited at the programme. All his poems centred on dignity and existence. He read some lines from his poem 'Gantabyahin' --

Just to know myself
I am observing
Everyone's face
Who is walking along the street?
(Translated from Nepali)

Besides, Shakya recited other four poems titled Mero Itihas Ko Euta Katha, Haraudai Gayeko Desh, Haat Bazaar and Yo Saharma. He also received great compliments from the audience when he recited this couplet, 'A Chyame (sweeper) is searching his country in the dust.'

Tanka Uprety was another guest poet who also presented five poems titled Ngyatapole, Pencil, Fingerprint, Bookmark and Ani. His poems were very short, sweet and subtle. Rich in images and symbols, his poems had the power to say a lot with a few words. They could be taken as an ocean in a drop.

"Mines are the poems of hope and resistance," he said. In his short poem Ngyatapole, he writes-

Why does the world
See on my pinnacle?
But the power
Is in my feet
(Translated from Nepali)

Rajani Mila, who writes in Nepal Bhasa, was another guest poet representing the third generation. She seemed to be an anti-conformist poet, a defiant. Her poems utter the powerful words of resistance which uncovers the real face of the state. She uses very unique images and symbols to express her thoughts. But she uses soft words also when she writes poems on love. She also recited five poems titled Gulab (The Rose), Government, You Will Commit Suicide, This City Is Lunatic, You Are A Hanger, My Story. In her poem 'My Story', she writes-

When I return in the red box
My children will think
Their mother died of choking on the breath
(Translated from Nepali)

The motive of the Sanjhya Sahitya group is said to promote budding poets and honour the established ones.

"We generally present three poets of three generations every month. Doing that we followed the rule of inclusiveness," Ram Gopal Ashutosh, one of the campaigners of the group, said. Based in Bhaktapur, this is a group of some promising authors including poet Ram Gopal Ashutosh, famous lyricist Harihar Timalsina, critic and poet Mahesh Paudyal, poet Nabin Prakash Shrestha who begun the campaign in November 2014. Activities of the group were postponed for some years due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

"Sanjhya has been running in its full swing for five months now," Nabin Prakash Shrestha, who is also a prominent poet in Nepal Bhasa, said.

According to him, there will be a Sanjhya serial at De Beans and Bitez Cafe in Naya Thimi on the third Saturday of every month. "Meanwhile, we will organise some special poetry events now and then," he added.

Acclaimed Chinese director Xie Fei to lead NIFF jury

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4



Acclaimed Chinese film directo Prof. Xie Fei, a two-time winner at the Berlin Film Festival, is set to visit Nepal as the main judge for the feature film competition at the Nepal International Film Festival (NIFF).

Festival coordinator KP Pathak has announced that Fei will also conduct a master class on film writing and direction during the festival.

Before the master class, his last film, 'Song of Tibet' will be screened at the festival.

Fei, who earned his Master's Degree from the Beijing Film Academy, received Berlin's second-highest honour, the 'Silver Bear,' for his 1990 film 'Black Snow.'

Three years later, his directorial work, 'Woman Sesame Oil Maker,' secured the prestigious 'Golden Bear' at the Berlin Film Festival.

Formerly the Vice-President of the Beijing Film Academy, Fei has been involved in teaching since 1980.

Although he has not directed any films since 2000, his influence is evident through his notable students, including renowned Chinese artists like Chen Kaige, Tian Zhuangzhuang, Zhang Yimou and Jia Zhangke.

At 80, Fei currently serves as the art consultant for the new generation of artists.

NIFF is scheduled to showcase 88 films from 40 different countries, encompassing feature films, shorts and documentaries.

Organisers plan to host workshops, discussions, and interactive sessions during the festival, addressing various film-related issues.

The film festival is set to take place from March 4 to March 18 in Kathmandu.

This year, alongside Fei, German actress, model, and artist Karin Angele, and Nepali actor Pradeep Khadka will serve as judges for the feature films at the festival.

Marilyn Manson completes community service



AP
Concord, Feb. 4

Marilyn Manson, who was sentenced to community service for blowing his nose on a videographer at a 2019 concert in New Hampshire, recently completed his time at an organization that provides meeting space for Alcoholics Anonymous and Al-Anon, according to court paperwork.

The shock rocker, 55, spent 20 hours last month at the Windsor Club of Glendale, a California nonprofit that provides meeting locations for Alcoholics Anonymous and families of alcoholics to "achieve a more meaningful life through recovery," according to the group's website.

A certificate of completion was filed by the Assistance League of Los Angeles with a New Hampshire court on Jan. 30. Manson had to file proof of his service by Feb. 4.

Manson, whose legal name is Brian Warner, pleaded no contest in September to the misdemeanor charge in Laconia, about 30 miles (48 kilometers) north of Concord, the state capital.

A no contest plea means Manson did not contest the charge and did not admit guilt.

He initially was charged with two misdemeanor counts of simple assault stemming from the encounter with the videographer at the Bank of New Hampshire Pavilion in Gilford on Aug. 19, 2019. The second charge, alleging that he spit on the videographer, was dropped.

Manson also was fined. He needs to remain arrest-free and notify local police of any New Hampshire performances for two years.

Prosecutor Andrew Livernois had said it was his first offense and he had no prior record.

Manson initially pleaded not guilty to both charges in 2021. His lawyer had said that the type of filming the videographer was doing commonly exposes videographers to "incidental contact" with bodily fluids.

Manson emerged as a musical star in the mid-1990s, known as much for courting public controversy as for hit songs like "The Beautiful People" and hit albums like 1996's "Antichrist Superstar" and 1998's "Mechanical Animals."

Last year, a California judge threw out key sections of Manson's lawsuit against his former fiancée, "Westworld" actor Evan Rachel Wood, claiming she fabricated public allegations that he sexually and physically abused her during their relationship and encouraged other women to do the same. He is appealing the ruling. The judge recently ruled that Manson cover Wood's legal fees, according to Rolling Stone.

Sculptors in Sunsari busy crafting Saraswati idols



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Inaruwa, Feb. 4

As 'Basant Panchami,' also known as 'Saraswati Puja,' is approaching, sculptors in Sunsari district are busy crafting idols of Saraswati, the goddess of wisdom.

Kamal Kishor Sharma from Gadhi Rural Municipality-3 is dedicating his craftsmanship to creating Saraswati idols. Many sculptors in Sunsari, including Sharma, have been actively encouraged to produce Saraswati idols for Saraswati Puja.

Saraswati Puja will be observed on February 14 this year.

This tradition has been consistent over the years, with the creation of Saraswati idols taking place across various locations in the district since January.

Binoj Kumar Yadav, a 35-year-old artist from Inaruwa Municipality-9, Babiya, said that he has been diligently working to craft 60 statues since the second week of December, with plans to complete 82 by February 12. Yadav, who crafted 50 idols the previous year, is aiming to make 82 idols this year.

Shankar Pandit from Koshi- 1 also affirmed that the work is in progress to create 60 idols.

Bijay Pandit of Inaruwa-9 said that considering the usage of idols in Saraswati Puja, they commenced the creation of artistic idols of Goddess Saraswati using clay.

This not only facilitates the process but also serves as a source of income.

Pandit said that he has been following this practice for the past 10 years during every Saraswati Puja.

It is customary to worship Saraswati by placing the idols in every campus school and educational institution throughout the district.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Addressing a disagreement in your community or friend group may be urgently necessary. As status-conscious Venus in your public 10th house clashes with touchy Chiron in your sign, your desire to look good.

Taurus: You may find yourself thinking hard about your goals today. Part of you might be excited for the possibility of doing something adventurous. Still, as fun-loving Venus in your 9th House of Expansion challenges.

Gemini: A pedantic approach risks alienating a loved one today. While mental Mercury meets profound Pluto in your philosophical 9th house, you may want to take an argument deep into the details. The situation provoking you might.

Cancer: You may need to rock the boat to move a close relationship out of a recent rut. Due to amiable Venus in your partnership zone conflicting with wounded Chiron in your ambitious 10th house, a shared goal is likely weighing on you.

Leo: The rules regarding a task you're held responsible for could seem totally unreasonable at this time. Although you're likely willing to contribute your fair share, that's potentially not what's being asked of you.

Virgo: Being too flippant regarding a serious matter could offend a companion of yours today. Although you may just want to cheer them up, that's not likely to succeed. With clever Mercury supporting perceptive Pluto in your productive 6th house.

Libra: You may currently crave comfort and peace at home, but addressing a relationship issue might be necessary before you can get that. You shouldn't have to give up your own pursuit of pleasure to please someone else.

Scorpio: Better planning could make your ongoing home life more pleasant. Figuring out how to open the conversation might be the hardest part, especially if you're afraid of hurting someone else's feelings.

Sagittarius: Your words hold a lot of power at the moment, whether or not you intend that. Meanwhile, you might not feel great about yourself. As abundant Venus in your finance zone engages with awkward.

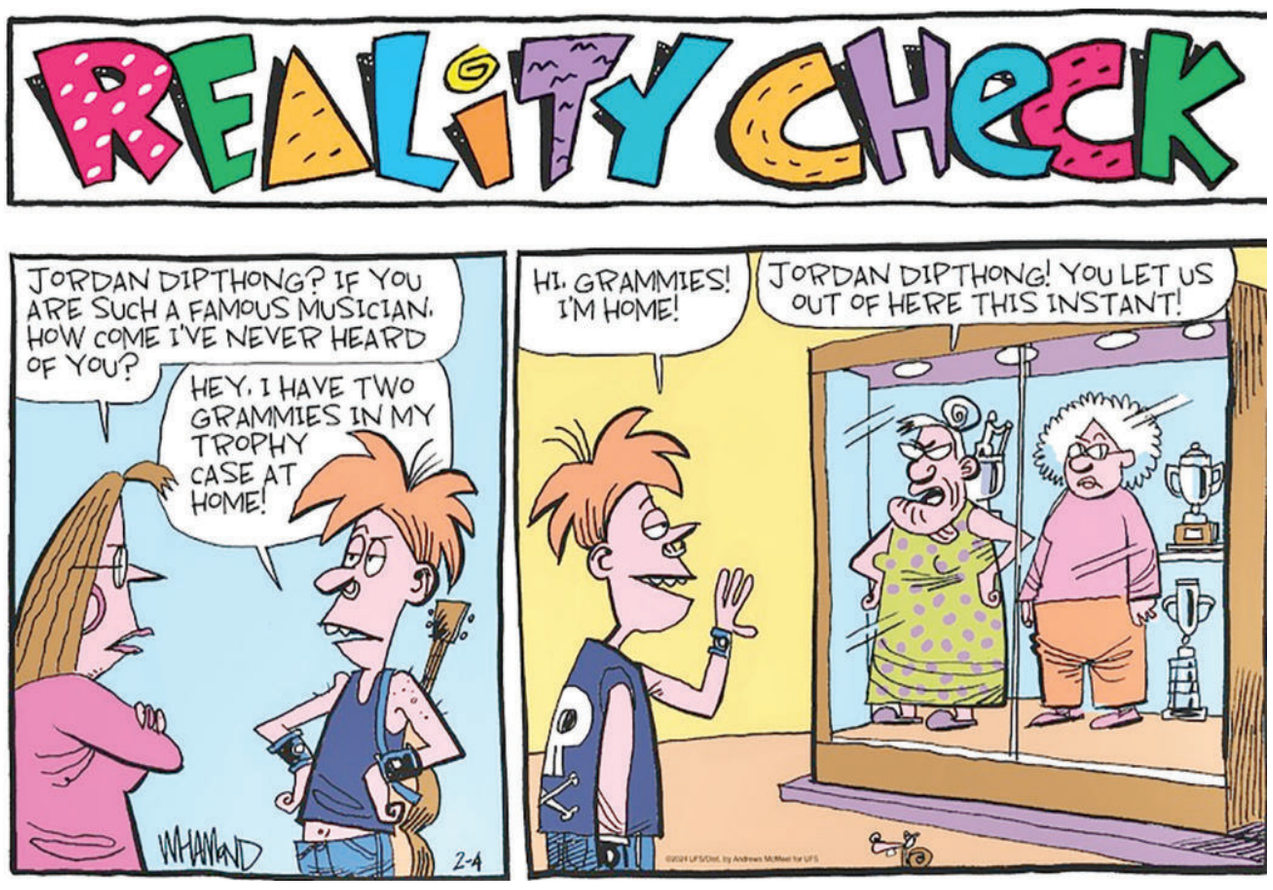
Capricorn: Doing something different from the way you were raised could have its challenges. Even if you're overall sure you made the right decision, there still might be times when following your own path is awkward.

Aquarius: Keeping a secret could now get you in hot water. Perhaps whatever you're hiding isn't that bad in and of itself, but the way you respond in a prying conversation might come off more hurtful than you intend.

Pisces: Digging deep into a big, juicy secret can be rewarding for you at the moment. As inquisitive Mercury sneaks into your mysterious 12th house, pulling a seemingly simple thread of curiosity.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



NEPALI GIRLS FINAL HOPES ALIVE AT SAFF U19



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Nepali U19 women's football team defeated Bhutan 1-0 in the South Asian Football Federation (SAFF) U-19 Women's Championship 2024 in Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Sunday.

Four teams – Nepal, Bangladesh, Bhutan and India – in the competition are playing against one another once in a league format. The top two teams with the most points after playing three matches each qualify for the finals.

After losing the first match of the tournament against Bangladesh 3-1 on Friday, Nepal's young women's team was desperate for a win against Bhutan. And the desperation led the team to keep their hopes for the finals alive.

The first half of the match against Bhutan went goalless. Regularly searching for a lead, Nepal's Senu Pariyar sent the ball to the back of the net in the 54th minute. Pariyar's goal was the decisive one that helped Nepal earn three important points.

Before the India-Bangladesh match kicked off Sunday night, Nepal sits in the third position trailing behind table-topper India and second-placed Bangladesh. To ensure a place in the finals, Nepal will have to defeat India as the two teams face each other on Tuesday.

England face record run chase in India

AFP
Visakhapatnam, Feb. 4

Shubman Gill struck form with a century as India left England a record victory target of 399 on day three of the second Test on Sunday.

England, who lead the five-match series 1-0, reached 67-1 at stumps after opener Ben Duckett fell for 28 in Visakhapatnam.

Left-hander Duckett put on an attacking 50-run stand with fellow opener Zak Crawley, batting on 29, before Ravichandran Ashwin got him out for his 497th Test wicket.

Nightwatchman Rehan Ahmed, on nine, joined Crawley with England needing another 332 for victory.

The highest fourth-innings target successfully chased against India is England's 378 at Edgbaston in 2022, and the most successful in India was when the hosts got 387 against England in 2008.

Spinners Tom Hartley and Ahmed combined to bowl out India for 255 after Gill's 104 on a day of bowling and fielding brilliance.

Veteran pace bowler James Anderson struck early to remove the openers, and India slipped further after a stunning catch by captain Ben Stokes before Gill stabilised the innings.

Gill hit his third Test ton, and first in his 12 innings since March 2023, to pull India out from 122-4 with two key stands including 89 runs with Axar Patel.

He reached the hundred with a single off debutant spinner Shoaib Bashir, and raised his bat to a cheering Sunday crowd.

Gill had two lucky escapes on four, both close lbw calls and one successfully reviewed, but then batted fluently with his flicks and drives until his exit.

England kept chipping away, as Hartley, who returned figures of 4-77 with his left-arm spin, sent back Axar lbw for 45 to leave India six down by tea.

Ashwin played a stubborn knock of 29 before Ahmed took him down to wrap up the innings with his third strike.



PHOTO: AP
England's Tom Hartley celebrates the wicket of India's Jasprit Bumrah on the third day of the second cricket test match in Visakhapatnam, Sunday.

Williamson, Ravindra tons punish SAfrica

Rachin Ravindra and Kane Williamson ground out unbeaten centuries as New Zealand punished a second-string South Africa on the opening day of the first Test at Mount Maunganui on Sunday. A Proteas side featuring six debutants paid heavily for deciding to bowl and spilling chances as the home side reached 258-2 at stumps.

Williamson was at his gritty best in reaching 112 off 259 balls, his 30th Test century, while Ravindra reached three figures for the first time and was unbeaten on 118 from 211 deliveries.

The pair combined for a stand of 219, wearing down an attack which began the day brightly after captain Neil Brand, on debut, opted to field on a green-tinged Bay Oval pitch.

Seamer Tshepo Moreki trapped Devon Conway leg before wicket with his first ball for South Africa before Dane Paterson removed Tom Latham to leave New Zealand 39-2.

Australia thumps WIndies, seal ODI series



AFP
Sydney, Feb. 4

Man of the match Sean Abbott grabbed three wickets and slammed an entertaining 69 as Australia cruised to an 83-run victory over the West Indies in the second one-day international to seal the three-match series on Sunday.

Chasing 258-9, the visitors were dismissed for 175 in the 44th over at a humid Sydney Cricket Ground.

Abbott starred with 3-40 while Josh Hazlewood took 3-43.

It was Australia's 11th consecutive ODI win to wrap up the series with a match to play in Canberra on Tuesday.

Australia won the first game in Melbourne by eight wickets and while it was a more disciplined bowling performance by the West Indies, their batters struggled against the hosts' relentless attack.

"I thought we stuck to our guns really well in the bowling department," said West Indies captain Shai Hope. "But the Aussies bowled very well and we need to find a way to bat a bit more freely." The West Indies run chase started with a flourish as Alick Athanaze slammed successive boundaries off Aaron Hardie.

But he was out the following ball for 11 and fellow opener Justin Greaves (eight) went the next over with Hazlewood -- back in the side for rested Melbourne bowling hero Xavier Bartlett -- doing the damage. When Kjorn Ottley was out for eight, caught behind off Abbott, they were struggling at 34-3.

Hope and Keacy Carty ground out a 53-run stand, but it took them 14 overs.

Hazlewood returned to bowl Hope for 29 and when Abbott accounted for Carty (40), the West Indies were 108-5 with the match slipping away.

Hazlewood struck again to remove Matthew Forde lbw and the night was capped by a sensational one-handed diving catch by Cameron Green to dismiss Roston Chase.

Earlier, Abbott hit 69 off 63 balls to help Australia post a respectable score after slumping to 167-7.

Explosive 21-year-old Jake Fraser-McGurk was handed a debut in place of Travis Head, but failed to fire after the West Indies won the toss and sent Australia in, out for 10 to Alzarri Joseph.

Joseph struck again seven balls later to remove Josh Inglis for nine, caught at backward point.

Green and Smith had steered Australia to their resounding win in Melbourne with an unbeaten 149-run stand.

But they were unable to repeat the feat with Forde bagging the key wicket of Smith, who chopped on to leave Australia tottering at 50-3.

FIRST UNIVERSITIES' SPORTS TOURNEY FROM TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

The Nepal Sports Council (NSC) is organising the first sports tournament among universities in the country in four sports – athletics, volleyball, table tennis and badminton – starting from Monday. According to the NSC, 280 players from 10 universities in the country are participating in the competition for 23 gold medals – 12 in athletics, one in volleyball, and five each in table tennis and badminton.

Athletics-related sports will be held in Dasharath Stadium, badminton in NSC's covered hall, table tennis in the Lainchaur-based National Table Tennis Training Centre and volleyball in Jawalakhel-based National Sports Centre. The tournament is two days long. "The university-level sports tournament has been initiated to promote sports among university students," said Shiva Koirala, vice chairman of the NSC.

Last-gasp AFCON triumph for I. Coast, SA also reach semis

AFP
Bouaké, Feb. 4

Oumar Diakite was the hero as hosts Ivory Coast staged another remarkable salvage operation on Saturday to reach the Africa cup of Nations semifinals, and South Africa later joined them.

A brilliant back-heel by the substitute in added time at the end of extra time in Bouake gave the Elephants a 2-1 victory over Mali, who dominated much of the quarter-final and scored first.

Ivory Coast-born Nene Dorgeles put Mali ahead on 71 minutes against the host nation, who were reduced to 10 men just before half-time when Odilon Kossounou was sent off.

But another Ivorian substitute, Simon Adingra, levelled in the 90th minute to take the pulsating west African showdown into extra time.

Then, with the quarter-final seemingly set to be decided by a penalty shootout, Diakite backheeled a drive from a teammate past Mali goalkeeper Djigui Diarra.

Diakite, who had been yellow-carded earlier, took off his shirt when celebrating, leading to a second caution followed by a red card.

Victory came at a high price as suspensions rule Diakite, Kossounou, captain Serge Aurier and Christian Kouame out of a semi-final against the Democratic Republic of Congo on Wednesday.

Victory maintained the dominance of the Elephants over the Eagles in AFCON tournaments -- it was their fifth win from 1994 with one other meeting drawn.

The last time Ivory Coast reached the semi-finals was in 2015 in Equatorial Guinea, and they defeated DR Congo 3-1 before going on to win the tournament a second time.

Meanwhile, South Africa goalkeeper Ronwen Williams saved four penalties in a shootout as his country beat Cape Verde 2-1 in a shootout after a 0-0 draw following extra time in Yamoussoukro.

Bryan Teixeira was the only Cape Verdean to score from the spot while Teboho Mokoena and Mothobi Mvala netted for South Africa.

South Africa are back in the semi-finals for the first time since 2000, when they lost to then co-hosts Nigeria, their opponents in Bouake on Wednesday.

Cape Verde could have won the match in added time at the end of regular time when Gilson Tavares broke through, but Williams pushed his shot on to the post and the ball was cleared.

ASHOK DECLARED BEST IN SPAIN OPEN TAEKWONDO



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 4

Ashok Khadka has been declared the best referee in the Spain Open Taekwondo Championship held from February 2-4 in Alicante, Spain.

He played the role of judge in both the Kyorugi and Poomsae categories in the championship organized by the World Olympic Taekwondo Federation. Ashok was named the best referee out of 12 judges from 8 different countries who officiated in the championship. The President of the World Olympic Taekwondo Federations Spain Chapter, Victor Pizarro Barcelo, presented Ashok with the best referee trophy.

Ashok is a certified 2nd Class International Judge in both Poomsae and Kyorugi categories of Taekwondo. He was promoted to the second class judge in Poomsae by World Taekwondo this month. In 2021, he was recognized as the second-class referee in the Kyorugi category. Additionally, two years ago, the Ministry of Youth and Sports honoured him with the best jury under the National Sports Talent Award. Ashok is also the only certified international judge from Nepal in all three disciplines of Kyorugi, Poomsae and Para.

Ashok, who is the President of Nepalese Taekwondo Academy, has judged more than 35 world-ranking tournaments in various parts of the world. He has previously been declared the best judge in the world-ranking competitions like SEONGNAM Open International Taekwondo 2023 held in South Korea, Japan Open Taekwondo 2022, Austrian Open Taekwondo 2021, German Open 2019 and many more.

Ashok passed the International Poomsae/Dan Examiner course in 2023 and the Master Instructor Course in 2016.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:51 am, Sunset at 5:44 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Generally cloudy in Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with partly cloudy in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at a few places of Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of hilly regions of rest of the country. Chances of light to moderate snowfall at some places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at a few places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the Provinces.

Expected Temp.: 15-17 Rain
Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.1	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	22.8	4.1	0.0
Dhangadi	23.7	9.0	0.0
Birendranagar	22.0	5.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	24.0	8.2	0.0
Jumla	15.2	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	21.7	6.9	0.0
Pokhara	20.0	8.9	0.0
Bhairahawa	23.4	6.6	0.0
Simara	23.3	8.0	0.0
Kathmandu	18.5	4.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	13.1	5.3	0.0
Taplejung	14.5	4.4	0.0
Dhankuta	19.5	7.0	0.0
Biratnagar	23.4	9.0	0.0
Jomsom	9.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	23.0	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	14.5	5.0	0.0*
Janakpur	24.8	7.8	0.0*
Jiri	12.7	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 5, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 142.79	Rs. 143.43
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.22	Rs. 167.98
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.76	Rs. 153.45
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.23	Rs. 86.62
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.34	Rs. 98.78
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.63	Rs.99.07
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.92	Rs. 8.96
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.41	Rs. 18.49
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.31	Rs. 36.48
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.74
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.20
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.89	Rs. 9.93
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.61	Rs. 12.67
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.16	Rs. 19.25
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.93	Rs. 17.00
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.15	Rs. 432.10
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.14	Rs. 352.73

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Qatar meets Iran in Asian Cup semifinals

AP
Al Rayyan, Feb. 4



Alireza Jahanbakhsh's last-minute penalty gave Iran a 2-1 win over Japan on Saturday and a place in the Asian Cup semifinals for just the second time since 2004.

Iran will next play tournament host Qatar, which beat Uzbekistan 3-2 in a penalty shootout following a 1-1 stalemate after extra time in their quarterfinal encounter.

Jahanbakhsh kept his cool in the sixth minute of second-half stoppage time to keep Iran on course for a first title since 1976 and fourth overall. Ko Itakura had been whistled for the foul and Jahanbakhsh gave goalkeeper Zion Suzuki no chance.

Iran came from behind after Hidemasa Morita put pre-tournament favorite Japan ahead in the first half of an entertaining quarterfinal match at Education City Stadium.

Mohammad Mohebi leveled the score in the 55th minute.

A first-half strike from Hassan Al Haydos led to defending champion Qatar taking a 27th-minute lead. His cross from the right deceived goalkeeper Utkir Yusupov, standing at the near post, and went in as an own-goal by the keeper.

Uzbekistan, looking for a second semifinal appearance, had chances and leveled after 59 minutes. Odiljon Hamrobekov picked up a loose ball just outside the area and the midfielder's shot found the bottom corner.

Uzbekistan continued to have better chances but could not prevent a penalty shootout.

Both goalkeepers made saves but Pedro Miguel scored the decisive kick to send Qatar through to the last four.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54